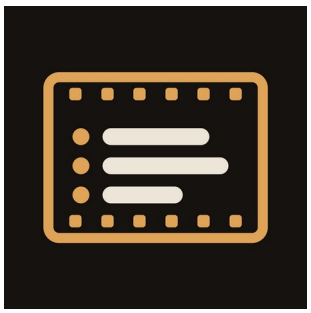
Ulf Marquardt
Writer · Director



Filmtext-o-Mat

User Manual

TV script writing with automatic timecode

Version 3.03 · October 2026

A gift from Ulf Marquardt

What the program does. The Filmtext-o-Mat is a tool for writing film narration and voice-over scripts. Every row has a start timecode, the narration text, a description of the sequence and a length. The key idea: you enter the **lengths** of the sequences – the program works out the timecodes itself. Insert or shorten something, and every following timecode moves automatically. With the film loaded it gets even faster: one keystroke sets the start of a passage exactly to the frame that is on screen.

Your data stays with you. The Filmtext-o-Mat runs entirely in your browser. Films and scripts are never uploaded anywhere – only the program itself comes from the internet.

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Support

1. Installing and starting

The Filmtext-o-Mat is a web app. There is nothing to download and nothing to set up: a link is all it takes, and the program runs on Windows, Mac, iPad, iPhone and Android.

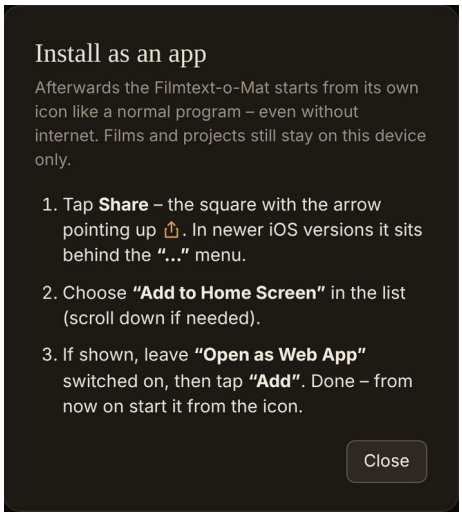
Starting from the link

Open the Filmtext-o-Mat with the **“Filmtext-o-Mat starten”** button on **ulf-marquardt.de**, and ideally bookmark it. **Chrome** or **Edge** are recommended: only they offer the real save dialog and find the film again automatically (chapters 6 and 8). Safari and Firefox work as well, with small limitations explained where they apply.

Installing as an app

Once installed, the Filmtext-o-Mat starts like a normal program: with its own icon, in its own window, without an address bar – and without internet. The toolbar has an **Install app** button for this. Inside the installed app it is hidden. The current version number is shown at the top next to the name.

- **Windows, Mac and Android with Chrome or Edge:** click **Install app** and confirm in the browser's dialog. If that dialog is not ready yet – Chrome and Edge only offer it once the page has been used for a moment – the button shows where to find installation in the browser instead: the install icon in the address bar or the browser menu.
- **iPhone and iPad:** there is no install dialog here, so the button shows a short guide: tap **Share** (the square with the arrow pointing up; in newer iOS versions behind the “…” menu), choose **“Add to Home Screen”** and confirm with **“Add”**.
- **Safari on the Mac (macOS 14 and later):** choose **“Add to Dock…”** from the **File** menu.
- **Firefox on a computer** cannot install web apps. The Filmtext-o-Mat simply runs in a normal browser tab there; the button explains this.



The install guide on an iPhone

Working offline and updates

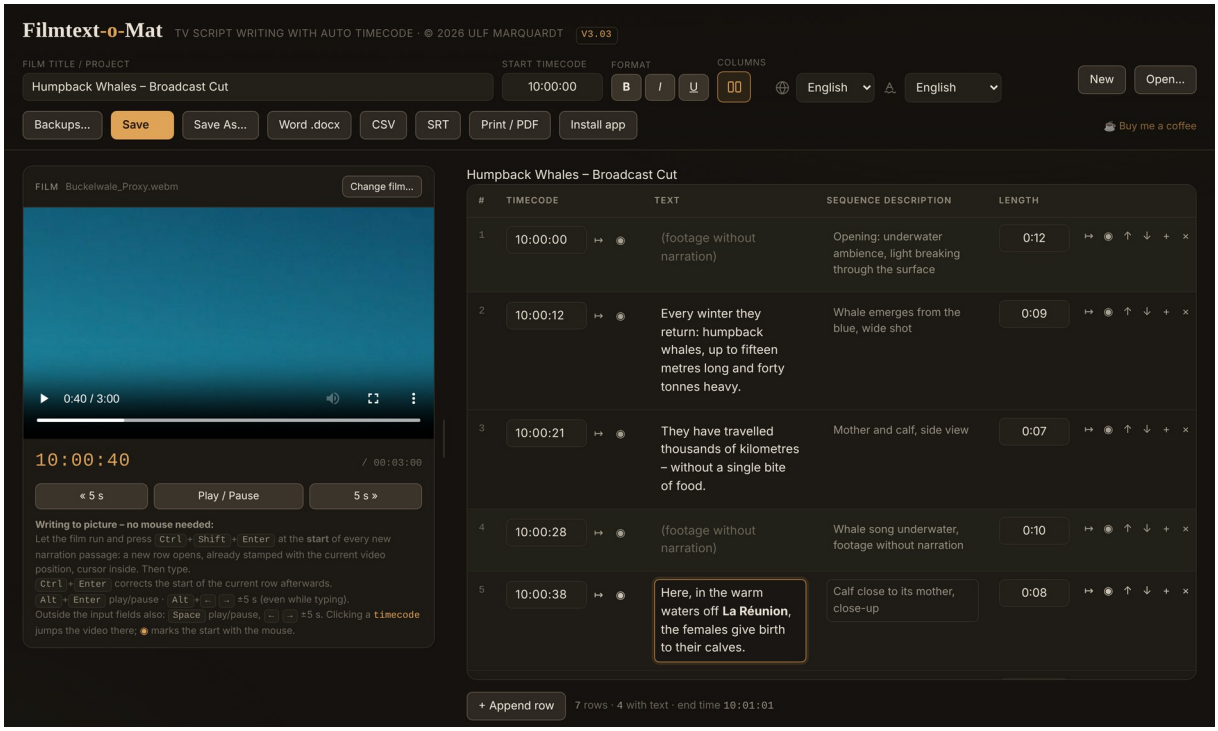
After the first start over the internet, the Filmtext-o-Mat also works offline – on location, on the train, in an edit suite without a network. When a connection is available, it fetches the newest version automatically at start-up. You never have to think about updates.

Interface language and script language

The toolbar has two pickers labelled with symbols instead of words, so they can be found in any language:

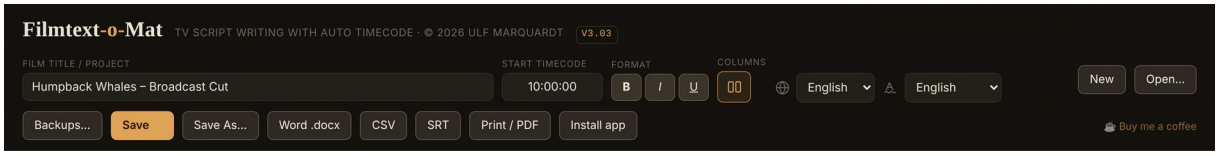
- **Globe – interface language:** German or English. Applies to this device and is remembered.
- **Letter symbol – language of the narration text:** German, English, French, Dutch, Spanish or Italian. It controls the browser's spellchecking and the column headings of the exports. This setting belongs to the project and is saved with it – so you can write an English script with a German interface.

2. The interface at a glance



The Filmtext-o-Mat with a film and a script loaded

At the top is the **toolbar** with film title, start timecode, formatting, the column switch, the two language pickers and the buttons for saving and exporting. On the left is the **film panel**, on the right the **script table**. Every table row is one sequence. Below the table you see the number of rows, how many of them contain text, and the end time. On narrow screens (an iPad in portrait, for example) the film moves above the table.



The toolbar

The four columns

- **Timecode** – the start of the row (hh:mm:ss). Calculated, but can also be edited by hand.
- **Text** – the narration. Leave it empty for pure picture or ambience sequences.
- **Sequence description** – what is on screen, as a note for you and the editors.
- **Length** – the duration of the sequence. Enter it as seconds (8), as m:ss (`1:30`) or as h:mm:ss.

Hiding the sequence description. When writing to picture, the narration needs the room. The switch under **Columns** (or `Alt` + `Shift` + `D`) hides the description column and shows it again. Nothing is lost: the descriptions stay in the project and in the exports.

3. The basic principle: lengths instead of timecodes

So that everything moves automatically when you insert or shorten something, the program calculates like this: the timecode of a row is the **start timecode plus the lengths of all rows above it**. Normally you maintain the lengths, and the timecodes follow by themselves.

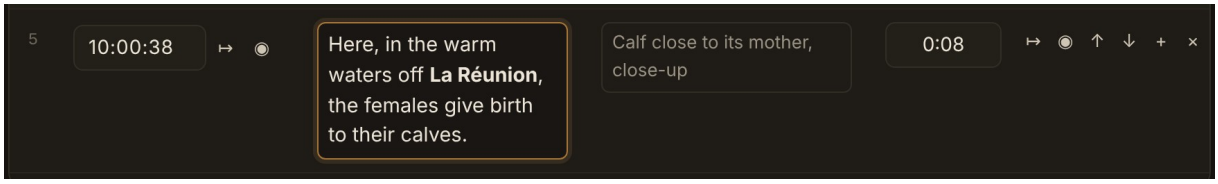
Example: you insert an 8-second sequence at 3:20 – every following row moves 8 seconds later. Shorten a length and they move earlier accordingly. At the bottom of the table, **End** and **Total length** are updated continuously.

Start timecode. The field at the top holds the timecode of the film's first frame. The default is 00:00:00; many broadcasters start at 10:00:00. All timecodes in the table and the clock below the film follow it.

Sequences without narration (opening titles, ambience, pure pictures) simply get a row of their own with length and description but no text. That keeps the timeline without gaps.

Timing is accurate to the second. That is exactly right for narration; frame-accurate work belongs in the edit or in a subtitle editor.

4. Working with rows



A row with its quick buttons on the left and right

Every row carries small buttons – right next to the timecode and again on the right of the row, so the mouse never has far to go:

- ↦ jumps the film to the start of this row.

- ◉ sets the start of this row to the current film position (chapter 6).
- ↑ / ↓ moves the row up or down.
- **+** inserts a new row below.
- **×** deletes the row.

+ Append row below the table adds a row at the end. If a film is loaded, it starts right at the current film position. Text fields grow automatically as you write.

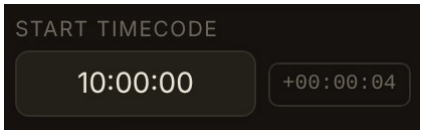
Formatting. Select text and click **B**, **I** or **U** in the toolbar – or press `Ctrl` + `B`, `I`, `U`. Bold, italic and underline are carried into the Word export and the printout, for example to mark emphasis for the narrator.

The **active row** is the row whose text or description field you clicked last. The keyboard shortcuts refer to it.

5. Entering timecodes by hand

You can also work without a finished film and type timecodes directly. Click into a row's timecode field and enter the start you want, for example 10:03:20. The row then starts exactly there; the length of the row above adjusts, and everything after it moves along. A value that would lie before the previous row is rejected, so the order always stays consistent.

Lead-in. If the first row starts later than the film's first frame – because the film opens with black or a logo, say – just type its timecode. The gap then appears as a small box next to the start timecode, for example **+00:00:04**. Clicking it removes the lead-in again.



Start timecode with a 4-second lead-in

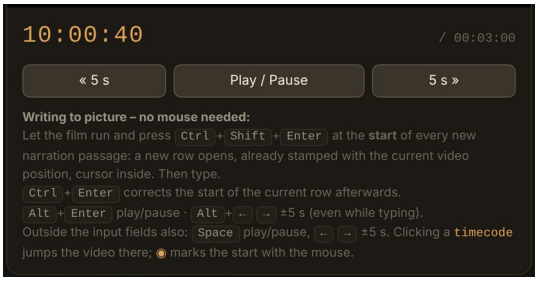
A typical workflow: write with typed timecodes first, load the finished film later and carry on in the same project.

6. Working with the film

Loading the film

Click **Choose a video file** on the left or simply drag the file onto that area. The film stays on your device and is never uploaded. Large files are no problem, because the browser only reads them.

Format. Browsers reliably play **MP4 (H.264)** and **WebM** – not ProRes, MXF, AVI, AVCHD and usually not H.265/HEVC either. If a file cannot be played, a notice appears. Make a small preview file (proxy) in MP4 from the master, with the **same length and frame rate** so the timecodes stay in sync – for example with HandBrake (frame rate set to “Same as source”) or FFmpeg.



The clock shows the film's timecode, with the playback buttons below

The large clock below the film shows the **timecode** of the current position – start timecode plus position in the file – so you can compare it with the table at a glance. To its right is the total duration of the file. The buttons **« 5 s**, **Play / Pause** and **5 s »** control the film.

Size of the film panel. Drag the vertical divider between film and table to the left or right. Double-click the divider to restore the default width. For a big picture there is also the player's full-screen button.

Writing to picture

This is how you work through the film block by block without touching the mouse:

1. Play the film (**Alt** + **Enter**).
2. At the **start** of a new narration passage, press **Ctrl** + **Shift** + **Enter**. At the end of the script this creates a new row that is already stamped with the current film position, with the cursor inside.
3. Type the text. The film can keep running.
4. If the start is not quite right, move the film to the right spot (**Alt** + ← / →) and correct the start of the active row with **Ctrl** + **Enter**. With the mouse, ◉ does the same.

Each stamp sets the length of the row above. So you enter the length of the **last** row yourself at the end – or append a short closing sequence and stamp its start.

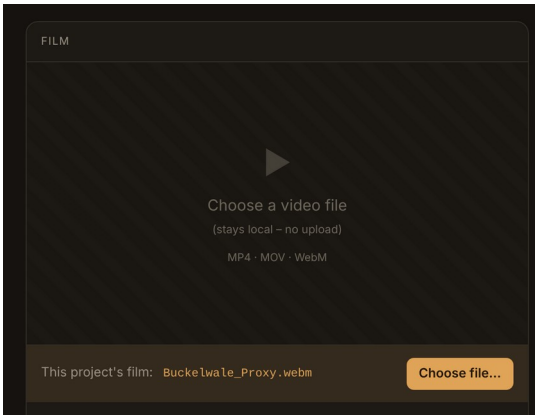
Ctrl + **Shift** + **Enter** in the middle of the script inserts the new row below the active one but does not stamp it. Otherwise everything after it would shift without you noticing.

Changing the film

When a new cut or a freshly rendered proxy arrives, click **Change film…** at the top of the film panel. The film is swapped, the script stays untouched, and the player stays at the same position. If the new version is shorter, it starts at 0. If it has a different lead-in, you only correct the start timecode.

The project remembers its film

When you save, the name of the video file is noted in the project – the film itself is not copied. When you open the project again, **Chrome** or **Edge** bring the film back by themselves whenever they can. After a browser restart they ask at most once: one click on ▶️ **Show film** is enough, no searching. Other browsers at least show which file belongs to the project; **Choose file…** opens the file picker.



Notice showing the film that belongs to this project

7. Keyboard shortcuts

Key	Function
`Ctrl` + `Enter`	Start of the active row = current film position (also while typing)
`Ctrl` + `Shift` + `Enter`	Insert a new row below the active one and jump into it; at the end of the script it is stamped right away
`Alt` + `Enter`	Play / pause the film (also while typing)
`Alt` + `←` / `→`	5 seconds back / forward (also while typing)
`Alt` + `Shift` + `D`	Hide / show the sequence description
`Ctrl` + `B` / `I` / `U`	Selected text bold / italic / underlined
`Space`	Play / pause the film (outside input fields)
`←` / `→`	5 seconds back / forward (outside input fields)
`Enter`	In a timecode or length field: confirm the entry
`Esc`	Close an open dialog

On a Mac `⌘` works instead of `Ctrl`; `Alt` is the `⌥` (Option) key.

8. Saving, opening and backups

- **Save** stores your work as a project file (`.json`). It contains everything: title, start timecode, all rows with their formatting, the script language and the name of the film. The dot on the Save button shows unsaved changes.
- **Save As…** saves under a new name or to another location.
- **Open…** loads a saved project file.
- **New** starts an empty script – asking first if anything is unsaved.

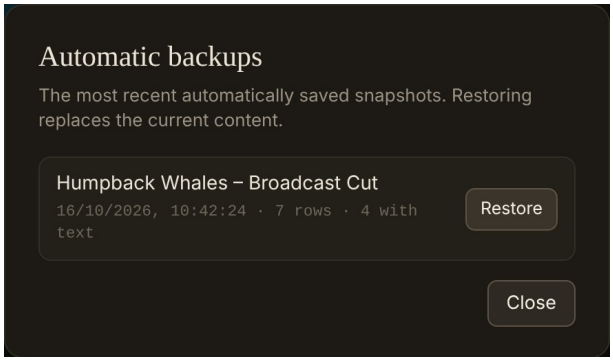
Where the file goes. In **Chrome and Edge on a computer** a real save dialog opens where you choose folder and name; every further “Save” updates the same file. In **Firefox and**

Safari, and on Android, the file goes to the downloads folder. On **iPhone and iPad** the share sheet opens: choose **“Save to Files”**. The suggested file name follows the film title.

Automatic backups

While you work, the Filmtext-o-Mat automatically backs up your work in the browser – two seconds after every change and every 30 seconds as well. “Auto-saved” with the time then appears at the bottom. The **five most recent snapshots** are kept; a new snapshot starts at most every two minutes.

If the tab was closed by accident or the computer crashed, the program offers the backups for restoring at the next start. They are always available via **Backups…**. If you close a tab with unsaved changes, the browser warns you first.

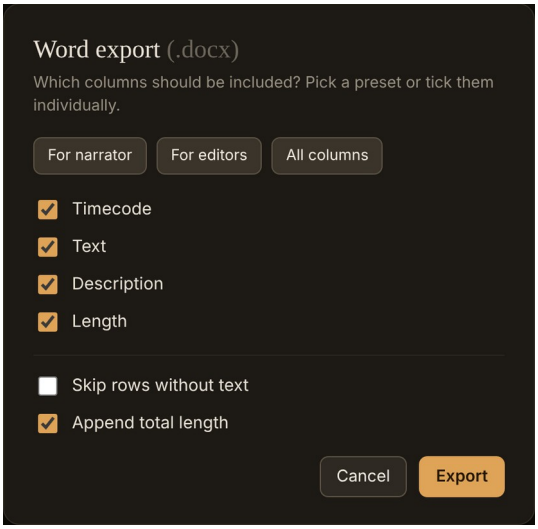


The “Automatic backups” dialog

> **Important:** automatic backups live only in the browser on this device. They do not replace saving to a file – and they disappear when you clear the browser data. Always save important versions with **Save**.

9. Exporting

Word (.docx)



Choosing columns for the Word export

The **Word .docx** button opens the column picker with three presets:

- **For narrator** – timecode and text only; rows without text are left out.
- **For editors** and **All columns** – all four columns, all rows.

You can also tick columns individually, skip rows without text and append the total length. The result is a current Word document in A4 portrait: Calibri 12 pt, 1.5 line spacing, an empty line after every paragraph. A text block is never split across a page – the narrator never has to turn the page mid-passage. Bold, italic and underline are kept.

CSV

The **CSV** button creates a spreadsheet file (semicolon-separated, UTF-8) with all four columns and the total length, ready to open in Excel or Numbers.

SRT (subtitles)

The **SRT** button creates a subtitle file. Every row with text becomes a subtitle (start = timecode, end = start + length); rows without text are skipped. Longer blocks are automatically split into chunks of at most 5 seconds, with the text spread evenly at word boundaries. Times count from the start of the film (0), regardless of the start timecode – so the file fits the video file directly.

The SRT is a good rough version. For broadcast subtitles, fine-tune the line breaks afterwards in a subtitle editor, such as Aegisub or the subtitle tools in DaVinci Resolve.

Print / PDF

The **Print / PDF** button opens the browser's print dialog, where you can also choose “Save as PDF”. The printout follows the Word export: same font size and line spacing, no block split across a page break, the table header repeated on every page. Controls and the film panel are hidden.

10. Questions and problems

On my iPad or iPhone I only see an empty page or a notice.

You probably opened the Filmtext-o-Mat as a file from Mail, a messenger or the Files app. These previews do not run programs. Open it from the link on ulf-marquardt.de instead – and ideally install it on your Home Screen right away (chapter 1).

The film won't play.

The browser does not support the format. Make an MP4 preview file (H.264) with the same length and frame rate (chapter 6).

After opening the project, the film is missing.

Click ▶️ **Show film** or **Choose file…** in the film panel. If the file has been moved or renamed in the meantime, choose it once more and save the project.

A timecode is not accepted.

A start may not lie before that of the previous row, and the first row may not start before the start timecode. Also check the start timecode: if it says 10:00:00, all timecodes in the table start at 10:00:00 too.

My automatic backups are gone.

They only live in that browser on that device. In another browser, in private mode or after clearing the browser data you will not see them. That is why important versions should always be saved as a file.

How do I get the newest version?

Automatically: if there is an internet connection at start-up, the Filmtext-o-Mat loads the newest version. Without a connection it keeps working with the last one loaded.

Does any of my data go to the internet?

No. Films, scripts and backups stay on your device. Only the program is loaded from the internet.

Support

The Filmtext-o-Mat is free. If it makes your work easier, I'd be glad of a coffee: the ☕ **Buy me a coffee** link is on the right of the toolbar. Suggestions and bug reports are welcome too.

Happy writing.

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